

Rubric for Evaluating a Conflict Forecasting Project

POS 6933: Conflict Forecasting Project

Total: 100 points

Criterion	Points	Full-Credit Expectations
Selection of a Theoretical Model	15	The project clearly identifies one theoretical model of conflict or political violence. The selected theory should be appropriate for conflict forecasting and should correspond to one of the major theoretical families discussed in the assignment, such as political opportunity, grievance, resource mobilization, democratization, modernization, regime characteristics, state capacity, polarization, repression, political shock, or natural resources. The paper explains why this theory should generate predictive signals about future conflict fatalities.
Theoretical Logic and Mechanisms	15	The project explains the mechanisms linking the theory to future conflict outcomes. The argument should clarify why the theoretical model should predict conflict fatalities across one or more future horizons. Strong projects distinguish between explanatory relevance and predictive usefulness. They also explain why the selected theory might improve prediction beyond simple lag-based benchmarks.
Operationalization of the Theory	20	The project translates the theory into a coherent block of measurable indicators from the available imputed dataset. Each variable is theoretically justified and, where possible, linked to existing literature. The paper identifies the total number of indicators, describes what each indicator captures, and explains how the indicators correspond to the selected theory. Strong projects group variables into theoretically meaningful dimensions rather than presenting an arbitrary list of predictors.
Forecasting Design and Temporal Structure	10	The project clearly defines the outcome, forecast horizons, training period, and test period. Strong projects also recognize the challenges of using slower-moving or annual indicators to predict monthly conflict outcomes.
Model Fitting with Two Algorithms	10	The theory-driven specification is estimated using two machine-learning algorithms selected from the approved options: Random Forest, Gradient Boosting Machine, or Neural Network. The paper explains why the two algorithms were selected and briefly describes how they work. If the student uses a variant or modified implementation, the choice is justified. Model fitting should be sufficiently transparent for the reader to understand what was estimated.
Benchmark Comparison	15	The project compares the theory-driven models against the two benchmark models developed earlier in the course. The comparison should be fair, consistent, and based on the same prediction rows where possible. The central question should be whether the theoretical model adds predictive value beyond the benchmarks.
Evaluation Metrics and Predictive Performance	10	The project evaluates out-of-sample predictive performance using appropriate metrics, including Mean Squared Error, Root Mean Squared Error, and Continuous Ranked Probability Score. Strong projects explain what each metric captures. If probabilistic predictions are used, the paper should also discuss uncertainty quality, such as interval coverage and sharpness. Results should be evaluated across all relevant forecast horizons.
Results Across Algorithms and Horizons	5	The paper assesses whether the theoretical model performs consistently across both selected algorithms and across the full set of forecast horizons. Strong projects do not rely on a single favorable result. They identify whether performance gains, if any, are stable, horizon-specific, algorithm-specific, or fragile.

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Substantive Interpretation and Implications	5	The conclusion explains what the results imply for the selected theory and for conflict forecasting more broadly. If the theory-driven model performs well, the paper explains why that matters. If it performs poorly, the paper explains what this reveals about the limits of the theory, the measurement strategy, or the forecasting task.
Professional Memo Structure, Tables, and Figures	5	The final memo is written in a professional research-paper format of approximately 7–10 pages. It includes clear sections on theory selection, operationalization, model fitting, evaluation, results, and conclusion. Tables and figures are readable, well labeled, and directly connected to the argument. Plots comparing models across metrics and horizons should be publication quality.
Total	100	